

CYBERSECURITY AWARENESS CAMPAIGN: PHISHING SIMULATION & EDUCATION

Document Type: Internship Project Deliverable (Task 2)

Target Audience: Academic Institutions & Remote Environments

Status: Completed

1. EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

In today's threat landscape, people are one of the most targeted weaknesses in organizational security. This campaign focuses on defense that centers around humans by creating two realistic phishing simulation scenarios. By examining specific psychological triggers, like urgency, curiosity, and fear, this project offers practical frameworks to change users from security risks into proactive human firewalls.

2. SIMULATION SCENARIO 1: CREDENTIAL HARVESTING

Threat Vector: Electronic Mail (Phishing)

Primary Target: Undergraduate Students, Faculty, and Institutional Staff

Attack Objective: Theft of centralized single sign-on (SSO) login credentials

Psychological Trigger: Artificial Urgency & Fear of Negative Consequences

Mock Email Template

From: Institutional IT Helpdesk

<security-alert@portal-verification-service.com>

To: [Target_User_Email]

Date: June 20, 2026

Subject: URGENT: Unusual Login Activity Detected - Action Required Within 24 Hours

Dear User,

Our automated security systems have detected an unauthorized login attempt to your institutional account from an unrecognized IP address outside your primary residential area. For your immediate safety, your digital access has been temporarily limited to emergency read-only status.

To restore full network privileges, protect your cloud data, and prevent permanent account deactivation, you must verify your identity right away by logging into our secure system synchronization portal below:

[👉 Click Here to Verify Your Account Credentials and Restore Access]

If you do not complete this required profile verification within 24 hours, your account will be permanently removed from the centralized institution server. Any unsaved academic progress, emails, and cloud storage contents will be permanently lost.

Sincerely,

Central IT Infrastructure & Security Team

Administrative Operations Control Center

Threat Analysis & Visual Red Flags

The Display Name vs. Actual Envelope Domain: Although the display name appears to be the "Institutional IT Helpdesk," the actual sending domain is @portal-verification-service.com. A legitimate institutional email would come strictly from the organization's official domain (e.g., .edu or [.ac.in](#)).

High-Pressure Time Constraints: The strict "24-hour" deadline is a tactic to induce panic, pushing the victim to act quickly without verifying the claim.

Generic, Non-Specific Salutations: The email starts with a generic "Dear User" instead of using the specific name of the student or employee. Automated internal security alerts usually address the recipient by name based on their database profile.

Hyperlink Masking (The Destination Gap): The text claims to link to a "Secure Portal," but hovering over the hyperlink reveals an external, unencrypted URL meant to mimic a legitimate login screen for credential theft.

3. SIMULATION SCENARIO 2: FINANCIAL DATA EXFILTRATION

Threat Vector: Electronic Mail (Phishing/Smishing)

Primary Target: General Public / Remote Logistics Workers Attack

Objective: Theft of Credit, Debit, or UPI Payment Credentials Psychological

Trigger: Curiosity & Low Financial Friction

Mock Email Template

From: Express Delivery Alert Center

<no-reply@delivery-update-tracking-portal.com>

To: [Target_User_Email]

Date: June 20, 2026

Subject: Delivery Failed: Outstanding Address Verification Fee for Package
#IN-88491-DL

Dear Customer,

We attempted to deliver your incoming parcel (Tracking ID: #IN-88491-DL) today around 11:30 AM. However, our delivery courier noticed an incomplete or missing residential address on the shipping label.

To successfully schedule a second delivery attempt for tomorrow morning, please update your address and pay the small address modification fee of ₹49.00.

Please access your secure tracking file to pay the pending balance:

<http://www.courier-tracking-update.in/pay/index.html>.

Note: If you do not settle this delivery processing fee by the end of the day, the package will be automatically returned to the originating warehouse.

Thank you for your cooperation.

Express Logistics Distribution Service
Global Tracking & Transit Management

Threat Analysis & Visual Red Flags

The Use of Unencrypted Protocols (HTTP vs HTTPS): The malicious link leads to an unencrypted <http://> address. Legitimate financial sites always use <https://> to ensure end-to-end Transport Layer Security (TLS) encryption.

Exploitation of Curiosity: Attackers often use vague tracking numbers (#IN-88491-DL) to exploit the recipient's curiosity, encouraging them to click in hopes of discovering the unexpected item sent to them.

The Low-Friction Financial Trap: By setting the required fee to a very small amount (₹49.00), the attacker lowers the victim's suspicion. The victim may justify that making a tiny payment is worth the risk to resolve the issue, unaware that the backend form is designed to steal their entire card profile or banking password.

4. EDUCATIONAL ARTIFACT: PHISHING PREVENTION CHEAT SHEET

This text is ready for distribution as a printable office flyer, digital attachment, or home cybersecurity guide.

THE 4-STEP S.A.F.E. FRAMEWORK TO STOP CYBER ATTACKS

1. Scrutinize the Sender Domain: Never trust a sender based only on the display name. Always click or tap on the sender's name to see the full email address. If a message claims to be from your bank or school, but the domain after the @ symbol ends in a random public address (like @gmail.com or @xyz-security-update.com), see it as an immediate threat.

2. Analyze Links Before Interacting: Before clicking any link in an email, hover your mouse directly over the link text without clicking. Look closely at the preview URL shown at the bottom corner of your browser. If the text says "yourbank.com" but the hidden URL points elsewhere, do not click it.

3. Filter Out High-Pressure Urgency: Legitimate organizations will not rush you to provide sensitive information, passwords, or financial details under the threat of account deletion. Treat any email that asks for immediate payment or quick login verification as a potential phishing attempt.

4. Establish Independent Verification: If you get an alarming notification, close the email right away. Open a new browser tab or window, manually type in the known, official website URL of the company or institution, and log in securely through your usual interface. Alternatively, contact the entity directly using a verified public phone number to check if the alert was real.

Pro-Tip for Family Device Security: The best tool to prevent successful phishing attacks is Multi-Factor Authentication (MFA). Even if an attacker tricks someone into entering a password, they won't gain access without the secondary code sent to your mobile phone. Turn on MFA for all your main accounts!